

Reflections That Lie

PART 1 — THE SMILE IN THE MIRROR

Elian Armitage had always hated the bathroom light.

It wasn't the color or the brightness that unsettled him. It was the way it exposed everything — a kind of surgical honesty, flooding every surface, every pore. The mirror reflected not just the image of a man, but the things he did not want to see: the tired skin beneath the eyes, the creeping fatigue of unslept weeks, the emptiness behind the stare.

He looked in the mirror that morning and noticed something strange.

He wasn't smiling. But his reflection was.

Only for a moment. A flash — a brief twitch of the mouth, the soft curl at the edge of a grin.

But he hadn't smiled. He was sure of it.

He stood frozen, toothbrush still in hand, foam dripping onto the sink. His heart thudded in his ears, blood warming his face. He leaned closer to the mirror, inspecting the version of himself on the other side.

Nothing. The face mirrored him perfectly now. The same dull green eyes. The same faint scar above the right eyebrow. Everything matched — or seemed to.

He turned away and shook his head.

"I need sleep," he muttered to no one.

But even after leaving the room, he felt the presence of something just behind him. Like he hadn't been alone. Like he still wasn't.

PART 2 — THE DOUBT

Sleep was scarce. Dreams were restless. Elian often woke at 3:13 AM — not 3:00, not 3:15 — always 3:13, as if something was programmed into him. A glitch in time. His apartment, cold and silent, stretched out like a void.

He avoided the bathroom mirror the next morning. Shaved using the reflection in the toaster, brushed his hair without looking.

Still, every surface that held the potential to reflect unnerved him. The microwave, the car window, the elevator panel — each was a potential doorway to that other version. The one that wasn't quite him.

At first, it was just a game in his head — a paranoia he could label. But it was growing harder to ignore.

He'd catch flashes in the corners of his vision. Smiles that didn't fade. Eyes that blinked too late. On the fifth day, he stared into the mirror again, daring himself, testing his reality.

The reflection blinked.

Then he blinked.

The order was wrong.

Elian staggered back from the mirror, stomach clenched in fear. There was a silence that didn't feel like silence at all — it felt aware.

He booked an appointment with Dr. Meera Shaw that night.

PART 3 — THERAPY

"I think there's something wrong with the mirror," he told her.

Meera had seen clients fracture under the weight of loss, under grief, under trauma. She'd seen war veterans, abuse survivors, brilliant minds crushed by madness.

But Elian was different. His descent was slower. Quieter. A man cracking from the inside out.

"I mean... not the mirror, maybe. The reflection. Me. I think he's... watching."

She offered no diagnosis. Not yet.

"Does he speak?"

"No," Elian said. "Not yet. He just... smiles. Sometimes. Or moves wrong. He looks like me, but... I can feel that he isn't."

She scribbled something in her notes.

"Elian, do you think it's possible you're projecting?"

He stared at her, unblinking. "I don't think I exist."

Meera froze.

"You don't think you exist?"

He nodded slowly. "I think the one in the mirror is the real one. And I'm the copy. I think... I'm fake."

PART 4 — SPLIT

Days bled together. Elian began filming himself sleeping, unsure if he was doing things at night he couldn't remember.

The videos showed nothing.

Until the sixth night.

At 3:13 AM, the camera lens caught movement. Not in the bed — but in the mirror.

A figure stood inside the glass. His figure. Elian's.

But the real Elian remained motionless in bed.

The figure stared at the camera. Smiled.

And waved.

PART 5 — DENIAL

Elian tried to destroy the mirror.

He wrapped it in a sheet, carried it into the alley, and shattered it with a hammer. Shards flew in every direction. Each one reflected his terrified face — a hundred versions of him, twisted and broken.

He breathed relief for the first time in days.

But when he returned to the apartment, the mirror was on the wall again.

Whole.

Untouched.

Waiting.

PART 6 — THE OTHER EL

He began calling him “El.” Short for Elian, but also for something else. Something older. Something ancient.

The mirror-El — El — started doing more.

Not mimicking. Leading.

When Elian raised his left hand, El raised the right. But then paused. Smirked. And kept his hand up while Elian lowered his.

The dominance had shifted.

El was in control.

Elian started locking doors. Covering reflective surfaces. Avoiding eye contact with his own soul. He heard whispers now. Not voices — not yet — but thoughts that weren’t his own.

Kill it, Elian. Kill the mirror.

You're not real. He is.

You're a copy, a shadow, a vessel.

PART 7 — COLLAPSE

Work was impossible. Socializing, torture. Everyone’s eyes looked like reflections — cold and false.

He lost weight. Forgot to eat. Time bent and blurred. The lines between the real and mirrored world began to fade.

And then Elian stopped appearing in mirrors altogether.

Only El was there.

PART 8 — REPLACEMENT

Elian no longer responded to his name. He would stand in front of the mirror, and El would talk.

No words, just expressions. A language of grins, shrugs, nods.

It became a form of worship.

Elian began mimicking him.

One day, he tried to enter the mirror. Physically. He pressed his hand against the glass until his fingers bled.

“Let me in,” he whispered.

El’s smile grew.

PART 9 — THE SWITCH

He woke one morning and everything felt off.

Colors were slightly wrong. Time ticked too smoothly. The sun rose in the west.

And in the mirror — Elan was brushing his teeth.

Smiling.

Elan reached out — but the glass was no longer reflective. It was a window.

He was trapped.

He screamed. Pounded on the glass. But El did not acknowledge him.

Because now... Elan was in the mirror.

And El was free.

PART 10 — SILENCE ON THIS SIDE

The apartment was quiet.

The man in the real world — El — lived freely. Took Elan’s name. Worked Elan’s job. Loved Elan’s life.

No one noticed.

Because El knew how to mimic perfectly.

In the mirror, Elan stood frozen. Trapped forever in glass. Watching a life he no longer lived.

And sometimes, in the dead of night, he would smile.

Just like El once did.

Waiting for someone else to look too long.

THE END